Saint Mary University

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Communicative English 1

Group Assignment

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Active and Passive Sentences in Present Tense

Introduction

Language is a powerful tool that allows us to communicate ideas, emotions, and information. One of the fundamental aspects of grammar is the distinction between active and passive voice. Understanding how to construct and use active and passive sentences in the present tense is essential for clear and effective communication. This document explores the definitions, structures, examples, common pitfalls, and applications of active and passive sentences in the present tense, with an advanced academic perspective.

1. Understanding Active Voice

Active voice is a grammatical structure in which the subject of the sentence performs the action expressed by the verb. It is direct, clear, and often preferred in both spoken and written communication, especially in contexts demanding clarity and assertiveness.

Structure of Active Voice in Present Tense

- **Formula:** Subject + Verb (present tense) + Object
- Example: "The professor elucidates the complex theory."

Characteristics

- The subject is the agent executing the action.
- The sentence is typically concise and unambiguous.
- Active voice foregrounds the subject’s role and agency.

Examples

- "The researcher analyzes the data meticulously, ensuring accuracy in every step."
- "Engineers design innovative solutions that address multifaceted challenges."
- "The committee evaluates the proposals with rigorous criteria and scholarly insight."

Textual Diagram: Active Voice Structure

Subject (Agent) ---> Verb (Present Tense) ---> Object (Recipient)

"The professor" ---> "elucidates" ---> "the complex theory"

2. Understanding Passive Voice

Passive voice is a grammatical construction where the subject receives the action of the verb. It is frequently employed in academic, scientific, and formal writing to emphasize the action or the recipient rather than the agent.

Structure of Passive Voice in Present Tense

- **Formula:** Subject + is/are + Past Participle + (by + Agent)
- Example: "The complex theory is elucidated by the professor."

Characteristics

- The subject is the recipient of the action.
- Passive constructions can introduce formality and objectivity.
- The agent may be omitted when unknown or irrelevant.

Examples

- "The data are analyzed meticulously by the researcher to ensure validity."

- "Innovative solutions are designed by engineers to meet evolving industry standards."
- "The proposals are evaluated by the committee based on empirical evidence."

Textual Diagram: Passive Voice Structure

Subject (Recipient) <--- is/are + Past Participle <--- (by Agent)

"The complex theory" <--- "is elucidated" <--- "by the professor"

3. Differences Between Active and Passive Voice

Aspect	Active Voice	Passive Voice
Focus	Agent performing the action	Recipient or action focus
Clarity	Direct, assertive	Indirect, formal, sometimes ambiguous **Passive Voice**
Usage	Narrative, persuasive, everyday communication	Academic, scientific, formal writing

Example Comparison

- Active: "The scientist formulates the hypothesis with innovative methodology."
- Passive: "The hypothesis is formulated by the scientist using innovative methodology."

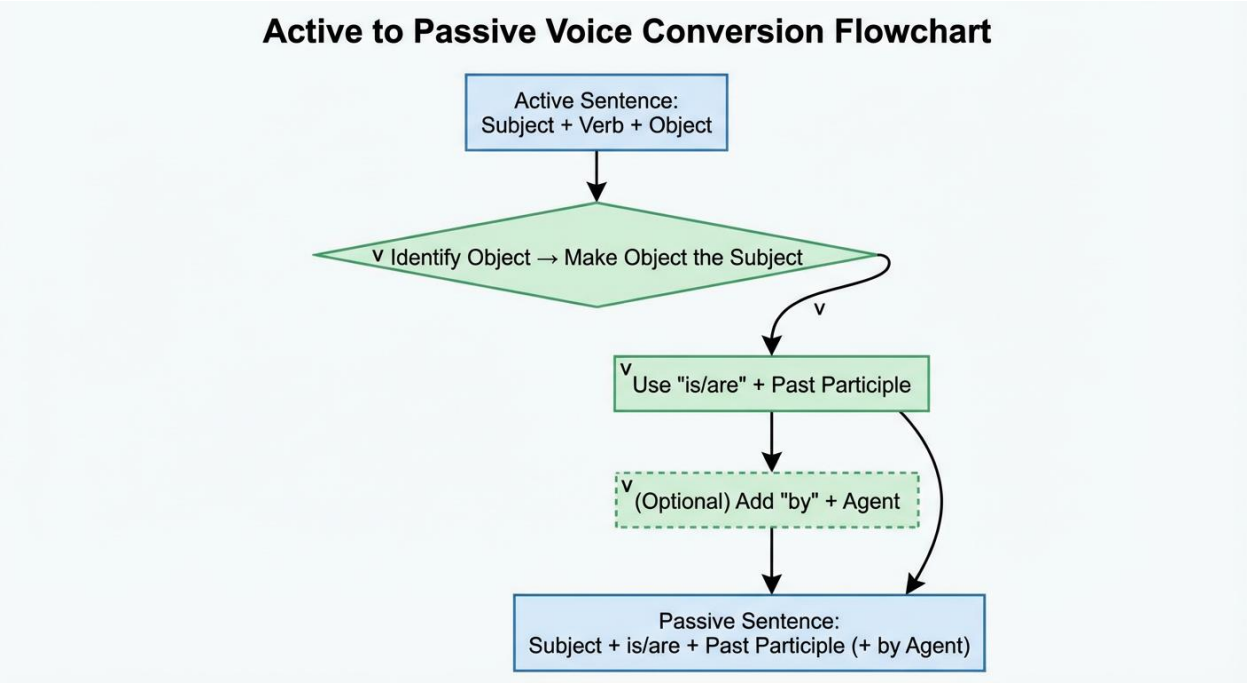
4. Rules for Forming Passive Sentences in Present Tense

1. Identify the object in the active sentence.
2. Promote the object to the subject position in the passive sentence.
3. Use the appropriate form of "to be" (is/are) matching the new subject.
4. Add the past participle of the main verb.
5. Optionally, include the agent introduced by "by".

Example Transformation

- Active: "The doctoral candidate presents the findings at the conference."
- Passive: "The findings are presented by the doctoral candidate at the conference."

Flowchart: Active to Passive Transformation



5. Usage of Active and Passive Voice

Active Voice

- Favored in contexts requiring clarity, directness, and engagement.
- Common in narrative, journalistic, and persuasive writing.
- Example: "The author argues the thesis convincingly, engaging the audience effectively."

Passive Voice

- Preferred in scientific reports, formal documentation, and when the agent is unknown or irrelevant.
- Conveys objectivity and detachment.
- Example: "The thesis is argued convincingly by the author, supported by extensive research."

6. Common Mistakes and How to Avoid Them

- **Excessive Passive Voice:** Can obscure meaning and reduce readability.
- **Incorrect Verb Forms:** Ensure correct past participle usage.
- **Agent Omission:** Sometimes necessary, but can cause ambiguity.
- **Subject-Verb Agreement Errors:** Especially in passive constructions with plural subjects.
- **Misplaced Modifiers:** Can confuse the agent and recipient roles.

Examples of Mistakes

- Incorrect: "The experiment is conduct by the team."
- Correct: "The experiment is conducted by the team."
- Incorrect: "The data is analyzed by the researchers."
- Correct: "The data are analyzed by the researchers."
- Incorrect: "The proposal was evaluated by carefully the committee."

- Correct: "The proposal was evaluated carefully by the committee."

7. Tips for Mastery

- Use active voice to emphasize the agent and create dynamic, engaging sentences.
- Use passive voice to highlight the action or recipient, especially when the agent is unknown or less important.
- Always check subject-verb agreement, particularly in passive sentences.
- Avoid overusing passive voice to maintain clarity and reader interest.
- When omitting the agent, ensure the sentence remains clear and unambiguous.
- Practice transforming sentences both ways to internalize structures.
- Read academic papers to observe effective use of passive constructions.

8. Exercises

Transform Active to Passive

1. Active: "The professor critiques the manuscript thoroughly." → Passive: "The manuscript is critiqued thoroughly by the professor."
2. Active: "The engineers develop the prototype using cutting-edge technology." → Passive: "The prototype is developed using cutting-edge technology by the engineers."
3. Active: "The committee reviews the applications with strict adherence to guidelines." → Passive: "The applications are reviewed with strict adherence to guidelines by the committee."

Transform Passive to Active

1. Passive: "The article is published by the journal with high impact." → Active: "The journal publishes the article with high impact."

2. Passive: "The experiments are conducted by the researchers following ethical standards." → Active: "The researchers conduct the experiments following ethical standards."
3. Passive: "The presentation is delivered by the speaker to an engaged audience." → Active: "The speaker delivers the presentation to an engaged audience."

9. Importance of Mastering Active and Passive Voice

- Enhances precision and clarity in academic and professional writing.
- Facilitates appropriate stylistic choices depending on context.
- Supports critical reading and writing skills in advanced studies.

Conclusion

Mastering active and passive sentences in the present tense is crucial for advanced English proficiency, particularly in academic and professional contexts. Understanding their nuanced differences and appropriate applications enables writers to communicate with clarity, formality, and stylistic sophistication. Through deliberate practice and analysis, learners can refine their command of English grammar to meet the demands of higher education and professional discourse.

References

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